‘court’ to settle personal disputes and began dispensing quick justice through the killer squad in cases he saw as serious violations of the Sikh religious code of conduct or where he saw a challenge to his authority.

The violence in Punjab continued unabated. In addition to the Nirankaris, senior leaders and functionaries of the ruling Congress party were not spared either. Chief Minister Darbara Singh survived an attack. A bomb was thrown into the house of a cabinet minister of Punjab as well as into the house of a Congress member of the Punjab legislative assembly. Bombs were also thrown to disturb India’s Republic Day celebrations at Amritsar on 26 January 1983. On 27 January, a branch of the Syndicate Bank was robbed. There was another attempt to rob a bank in April 1983. But specific and targeted killings, which destroyed the morale of the police, were yet to come. [2]

To reassert his leadership, in April 1983 Longowal launched a ‘rasta roko’ (block the roads) agitation, which attracted significant response from the Sikhs of Punjab. The transport system was completely paralysed, and bloody clashes with the police followed. The response to his call for agitation encouraged Longowal to order Bhindranwale to take an oath of loyalty to him, which the latter reluctantly did. But the bonhomie didn’t last long. During the course of the agitation, a Home Guard armoury in Ferozepur district was looted by extremists. In the last week of April 1983, Longowal announced in Amritsar the creation of a voluntary force of one lakh Sikhs, to be known as ‘marjiwares’ – the do-or-die squad. [3]

‘By this time Bhindranwale and his men were above the law. It needed sanction of the prime minister’s think-tank before they could be arrested and that sanction was not coming.’ [4] Bhindranwale’s unbridled activities were terrorizing the Hindus of Punjab, who wanted an end to his reign of terror as soon as possible. However, the time had not yet come. The 1 Akbar Road group was busy trying to ensure two things. First, hopes of a negotiated settlement with the Akalis were to be kept alive for some more time. For that the Akalis had to continue their agitation programme to build pressure on the Central government to invite them for another round of